

Three AI work surfaces

Chat · Work · Code — the labels vary by product

The **surface** is the environment where you work with an AI model. The model may be similar across surfaces; what changes is the context it can use, the actions it can take, and how much setup or oversight the task requires.

EXAMPLES ACROSS PROVIDERS

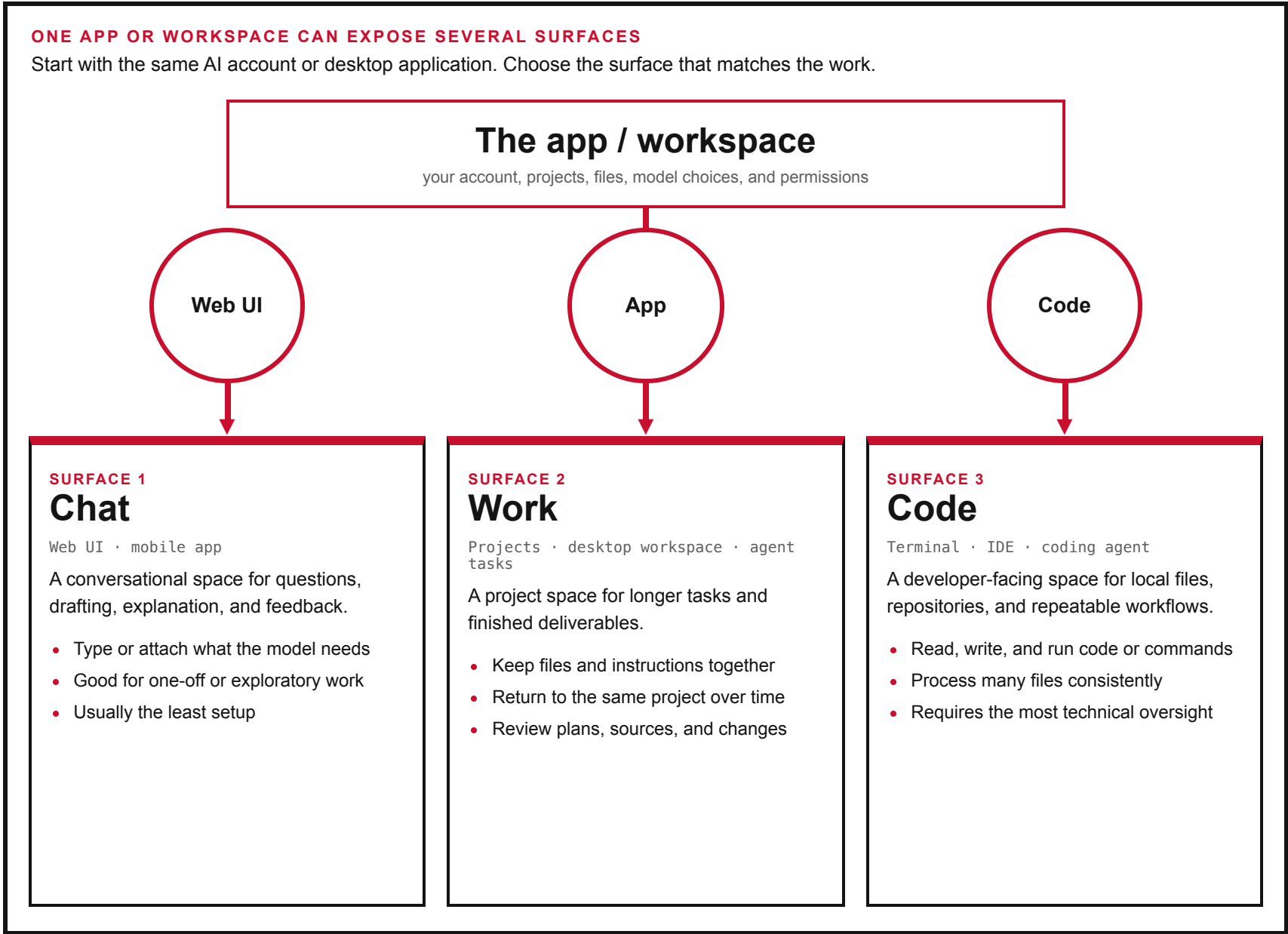
OpenAI
GPT models
ChatGPT · Work · Codex

Anthropic
Claude models
Claude · Cowork · Claude Code

Google
Gemini models
Gemini · Workspace tools

Microsoft
Copilot
Product features vary

These names and features change. Check your plan and institution's settings. The three surfaces below describe a useful pattern, not a promise that every provider offers every surface.



Surface, model, and permissions

The interface is only one part of the system

A product name does not tell you exactly what the AI can see or do. Check the model, connected data, tools, and approval settings for the particular account and task.

WHAT TO CHECK

MODEL • Which model is selected? • What are its limits for length, images, code, and reasoning? • Is the result important enough to verify against a source?	CONTEXT • Which messages, files, project notes, or connected apps are included? • Could sensitive information be in that context? • Can the model distinguish instructions from untrusted source text?	ACTIONS • Can it only suggest, or can it edit files and run commands? • Does it ask before taking a consequential action? • Can you inspect and undo the changes?
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PROVIDER EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

OpenAI: ChatGPT provides Chat and Work in the current desktop experience; Codex is the coding surface. Availability depends on account and plan.	Anthropic: Claude provides browser chat; Cowork and Claude Code add project, desktop, or terminal-based work. Availability depends on account and plan.	Other providers: Gemini, Copilot, and other systems use different product names and combinations. Map their features to Chat, Work, and Code by checking what context and actions they support.
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PRACTICAL RULE

Use **Chat** when you need a conversation. Use **Work** when you need a project and a deliverable. Use **Code** when you need a repeatable operation on files or software. In every surface, read the plan, inspect the source, and check the result.

Product names and availability change. This handout describes a comparison framework for the workshop; consult the provider's current documentation and your institution's policies before using connected data or granting permissions.